

Say–Mean–Matter in Routine Argument Writing

Say-Mean-Matter helps students question a text, search for deeper meanings, and make connections between the text and their lives.

Suggested sentence templates for Say–Mean–Matter:

SAY What does the text say? Direct quote, paraphrase, or summary	MEAN What does this information mean? Make an inference. Interpret and “read between the lines.” • What does the author mean? • How can the information be interpreted? • What can be inferred? • What point is the author making?	MATTER Why does it matter? So what? What are the implications and/or possible outcomes? • Why does this information matter? • Why is this important or significant? • What are the implications or consequences of the information? • How does this connect to other ideas?
• X[*] states/says/writes ... • X claims/argues/insists ... • According to X, ... • X reminds us that ... • As X points out ... <i>*X is the author or source</i>	• This quote/evidence/idea + means/emphasizes/shows ... • This suggests/implies ... • In other words, X believes ... • Basically, X is saying ... • X’s point is that ...	• As a result, ... • Also/In addition, ... • For example/instance, ... • In my experience, ... • This connects/relates to ... • Knowing this will ...

Try it out: The Raven by Edgar Allan Poe

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“Once upon a midnight dreary, while I pondered, weak and weary...”	<i>The speaker is physically and mentally exhausted, suggesting he is already struggling emotionally before the raven</i>	<i>This matters because it shows the speaker is vulnerable, which helps explain why he becomes so disturbed</i>

	<i>appears.</i>	<i>by the raven later in the poem.</i>
<i>The raven repeatedly answers the speaker's questions with the word "Nevermore."</i>	<i>The raven symbolizes the speaker's inability to escape his grief and loss. Each answer reinforces his hopeless thoughts.</i>	<i>This matters because it shows how the speaker's own mind traps him in sorrow, revealing the poem's focus on ongoing grief.</i>
<i>The speaker asks if he will ever reunite with Lenore, and the raven again says "Nevermore."</i>	<i>The speaker interprets this as confirmation that his loss is permanent and that he will never find peace.</i>	<i>This matters because it marks the turning point where the speaker fully gives in to despair, showing how grief can consume someone over time.</i>